

Managing Arthritis Flare-Ups at Home

How to manage an arthritis flare-up at home. UK guide to pain relief, rest vs activity, when to call your GP, and creating a personalised flare-up action plan.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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Arthritis flare-ups can strike unexpectedly, bringing intense pain, swelling, and fatigue. Having a plan in place helps you manage flares confidently at home while knowing when to seek medical help.

Recognising a Flare

- Increased joint pain beyond your usual baseline
 - New or worsening swelling
 - Extended morning stiffness (over 30-60 minutes)
 - Extreme fatigue
 - Difficulty performing normal daily tasks
 - Feeling generally unwell
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Immediate Flare Management



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Pain Relief

- Paracetamol — take regularly (up to 4g daily) rather than waiting for severe pain
- NSAIDs — ibuprofen or naproxen if suitable for you (check with your pharmacist)
- Topical treatments — anti-inflammatory gels directly on affected joints
- Heat — warm baths, wheat bags, or hot water bottles for stiff joints
- Cold — ice packs wrapped in a towel for 15 minutes on acutely swollen joints

Rest vs Activity

The right balance is crucial:

- Rest the acutely inflamed joints but keep other joints moving

- Gentle range-of-motion exercises — just moving joints through their range, no resistance
- Short walks if tolerable — even 5 minutes helps prevent stiffness
- Avoid complete bed rest — it leads to deconditioning and more stiffness

Pacing

- Break tasks into small chunks
 - Alternate between activity and rest
 - Prioritise essential tasks and let non-essentials wait
 - Accept help from others — it's not weakness
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Your Flare-Up Action Plan

Create a written plan to follow when flares strike:

- Level 1 (Mild flare) — increase pain relief, apply heat/cold, gentle movement, continue daily routine with modifications
 - Level 2 (Moderate flare) — maximum regular pain relief, reduce activities to essentials, contact GP if lasting >3 days
 - Level 3 (Severe flare) — contact GP or rheumatology helpline, may need steroid injection or short oral steroid course
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When to Contact Your GP



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- Flare lasting more than 3-5 days without improvement
- Single hot, very swollen joint (needs urgent assessment to rule out infection)
- Fever or feeling systemically unwell
- Unable to manage pain with usual medications
- New symptoms you haven't experienced before

Preventing Future Flares

- Take medications as prescribed — don't skip doses when feeling well
- Manage stress — stress is a common flare trigger
- Get adequate sleep
- Pace activities to avoid overexertion

- Keep a flare diary to identify your personal triggers

Flares are a normal part of living with arthritis. Having a plan reduces anxiety and helps you regain control faster. Discuss your personalised flare plan with your rheumatology team.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about managing arthritis flare-ups at home?

Short answer: Managing arthritis flare-ups involves a multi-pronged approach at home.

Regularly take paracetamol (up to 4g daily) or suitable NSAIDs, and use topical treatments. Apply heat for stiffness, cold for swelling. Balance rest for acutely inflamed joints with gentle movement and short walks. Create an action plan: for mild flares, increase pain relief; for moderate, reduce activities; for severe, contact your GP, especially if lasting over 3-5 days.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.